

CampusConnect

Local Project Setup Guide

Follow these steps in order to get the CampusConnect project running on your machine.

Required Node.js version: 24.11.0

STEP 1 Clone the repository

```
git clone https://github.com/yashvskothari/CampusConnect.git
```

STEP 2 Install dependencies

Run this in the **root** folder first:

```
npm install
```

The project has two main folders: **client** (frontend) and **server** (backend). Go into each one and run the same command:

```
cd client
npm install

cd ../server
npm install
```

STEP 3 Create the server .env file

Inside the **server** folder, create a file named **.env** with the following:

```
DATABASE_URL=postgresql://neondb_owner:npg_vH5Mh0aF4lxt@ep-autumn-base-azi0xtnm-pooler.c-3.ap-southeast-1.amazonaws.com/neondb?sslmode=require

JWT_SECRET=*****

JWT_EXPIRES=7d

PORT=5000

CLIENT_URL=http://localhost:5173
```

Treat this .env file as a secret. Don't commit it to git or share it outside the team.

STEP 4 Generate a JWT secret

In a PowerShell terminal, run:

```
[guid]::NewGuid().ToString()
```

You'll get something like (yours will be different):

```
7f3c2a91-8b4d-4e6f-a123-9c8d7b6e5f42
```

Copy that string into **JWT_SECRET** in the server's .env file, replacing the placeholder *********.

STEP 5 Create the client .env file

In the **client** folder, create a file named **.env** with:

```
VITE_API_URL=http://localhost:5000/api  
VITE_SOCKET_URL=http://localhost:5000
```

STEP 6 Create the client .env.production file

Also in the **client** folder, create a file named **.env.production** with:

```
VITE_API_URL=https://campusconnect-server.onrender.com/api  
VITE_SOCKET_URL=https://campusconnect-server.onrender.com
```

This one is used automatically when the app is built for production (deployment) — you don't need to touch it for local development.

STEP 7 Generate the database client

Back in the **server** folder, run:

```
npm run db:generate
```

STEP 8 Start the backend server

Still inside **server**:

```
npm run dev
```

Keep this terminal running — the backend needs to stay active.

STEP 9 Start the frontend server

Open a **new terminal**, go to the **client** folder, and run:

```
npm run dev
```

STEP 10 Open the app

With both servers running, visit:

```
http://localhost:5173
```

Quick Checklist

#	Task
1	Node.js v24.11.0 installed
2	Repo cloned
3	npm install run in root, client, and server
4	server/.env created with DATABASE_URL, JWT_SECRET, JWT_EXPIRES, PORT, CLIENT_URL
5	client/.env created with VITE_API_URL, VITE_SOCKET_URL
6	client/.env.production created
7	npm run db:generate run in server
8	Backend running (npm run dev in server)
9	Frontend running (npm run dev in client)
10	App loads at localhost:5173